



## State of anticipation

J&K should be given its Statehood  
without any further delay

In a resolution passed on September 28, the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly called upon the Government of India for the “immediate and urgent restoration of full Statehood” to the nearly seven-year-old Union Territory (UT). The erstwhile State of J&K was downgraded and carved out into two UTs in 2019 when the Centre decided to end the region’s close to 70 years of special constitutional status. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah moved the resolution with a reminder of the past resolutions adopted by the Assembly over the demand of special status. It mentioned the greater autonomy resolution of June 26, 2000, and the special status resolution of November 6, 2024. Other than the 29 BJP legislators, the members of the 90-member House broadly supported the resolution after an intense and high-pitched debate on Statehood and special status. It was a rare bid by Mr. Abdullah on Statehood since he won the election two years ago. Both the ruling alliance parties, the Congress, CPI(M) and Independents, as well as the Opposition parties, including the Peoples Democratic Party, J&K Peoples Conference, Aam Aadmi Party and Awami Ittehad Party extended their support to the demand. The Centre itself laid down a three-step path for the restoration of Statehood: delimitation, election and Statehood. The Supreme Court of India had sought the restoration of Statehood “as soon as possible”, while Prime Minister Narendra Modi had promised the same “at the appropriate time”, both in Parliament and outside it. Still, the wait has been too long for not only the people of J&K, but for all those who value democracy and federalism.

Ideological positions aside, the downgrading of J&K from a full-fledged functional State to a UT was unprecedented and unhealthy. No doubt, J&K went through three decades of tumultuous times, as militant violence and deaths became the order of the day. However, the 2024 elections were an unprecedented departure from the past. Voters in Kashmir shunned boycott politics and J&K recorded 63.88% voting. It was the most peaceful election with not a bullet fired, a first in the past three decades. The Centre should have reciprocated the people’s faith in the democratic set-up by empowering the legislature they voted for. The first step in that direction is the restoration of Statehood. The scarred and painful past of J&K needs healing. It is high time that the Court’s direction on Statehood be respected and implemented without delay. An empowered legislature rather than the streets, should become the space for conversation with the Centre on J&K. J&K should not be allowed to drift away from the federal and democratic process in India. To predicate restoration of Statehood on the end of militancy is, as Mr. Abdullah indicated, equivalent to giving Pakistan and its strategy of state-sponsored terrorism a say in the matter.

## Silver lining

In Chess Olympiad, India coming second  
to Uzbekistan should not be dispiriting

When the Indian men finish as the runner-up and the women secure third place in one of the world’s biggest sporting events, it calls for celebration. But, when the fact is that those performances did not quite live up to the expectations, it says a lot about the reputation India enjoys as a chess giant. The Indians’ show at the Chess Olympiad, which concluded at Samarkand on Sunday, is no doubt commendable, as they retained the Gaprindashvili Trophy, awarded to the best country overall, and claimed six individual medals as well. In a tournament in which more than 200 countries took part, that is no small feat. Still, for a nation that had won both the open and women’s titles two years ago in Budapest, the failure to defend even one is a bit of a disappointment. The Indian men were seeded second, while the women had the top billing. So, the men played according to their ranking, as the host Uzbekistan, the only country that could challenge India when it comes to the depth of young chess talent, emerged as the champion. The clash between the two teams was the most anticipated one at the tournament, and it was always going to be crucial. So it proved.

Uzbekistan beat India in the sixth round, moved into the sole position, and inched towards the gold; not even a shocking defeat to Germany mattered in the end. The Indian women’s winning run had been stopped in the fifth round, by Poland. They had to fight hard then to win even bronze. The Chinese women were the deserving winners, even though they had not fielded some of their best players. That four Indian women – out of the five – won individual medals proves it was a fine team effort, and yet B. Savitha Shri stood out. The Chennai teenager was making her Olympiad debut, coming in place of the vastly experienced D. Harika, who chose to stay away this time, and she was brilliant right through the event. Of her 10 games, she won eight and drew the other two. Savitha deserves all the support she requires to make further progress on the chessboard. Remember, India does not have the kind of bench strength in women’s chess that it possesses in the men’s game. D. Gukesh, though playing on the fourth board, could not have timed his individual silver better: after becoming the youngest World champion in history in 2024, he has had a tough time. He is defending his crown against Uzbekistan’s Javokhir Sindarov in the match starting in Geneva on November 24. The Olympiad would only have helped him recover some of his confidence and persistence.

At their core, educational institutions are intended to be ‘temples of empiricism’. Their entire legitimacy rests on a single, unforgiving premise: that truth is discovered through observation, experimentation, and peer-reviewed verification, not through revelation, tradition, or charismatic authority. The scientific method thrives on questioning, falsifiability, and rigorous doubt – virtues that stand in direct opposition to belief, spiritualism, and uncritical reverence. This is not a mere aesthetic choice or a harmless nod to cultural heritage; it is a profound philosophical contradiction. This raises a disquieting question: when an academic institute prioritises spiritual performance and political deference over intellectual rigour, does it erode the very foundation of its own mission?

### Reason versus reverence

Knowledge advances not by revering the past, but by challenging it. Newton’s famous “shoulders of giants” line was half-jest – not a call to worship, but to build critically on past work. History shows this: Galileo, Darwin, and Einstein each overturned once-sacred truths. This relentless, iconoclastic spirit is the engine of human knowledge. When a university or research body such as the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) introduces feudalistic, socially hierarchical etiquette – requiring students to bow before dignitaries and formal functions such as convocations suffused with religious incantations – it transmits a deeply corrosive message.

Consider the 2026 convocation ceremony, in August, at IIT Delhi, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi was the chief guest. Reports surrounding the ceremony highlighted two practices that drew criticism: students were reportedly instructed on how far to bow while receiving medals from the Prime Minister, and were reportedly asked to stand during Vedic chants.

In a secular, democratic republic, these are ideological statements with far-reaching consequences. By doing so, the institution subtly endorses the idea that the state and its functionaries operate under a supernatural mandate, a concept antithetical to the rational, evidence-based framework of a modern republic.

The bowing protocol resurrects a pre-modern, courtly hierarchy that has no place in an institution ostensibly committed to meritocracy and intellectual emancipation. It infantilises the graduating students, reducing them from autonomous, critical thinkers to supplicants seeking the favour of a political figure. Yet, it is precisely here that the ceremony reveals its deepest irony: the Prime Minister – a self-avowed votary of his religious practices – used his address to urge students to question conventional



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Academic institutions must remain spaces for scepticism, dissent and fearless inquiry

wisdom and challenge accepted traditions. The dissonance between the ritual performance and the rhetorical exhortation could hardly be more pronounced. This performative contradiction reveals the ceremony for what it is: a carefully orchestrated spectacle of power, where the substance of the message is sacrificed for the optics of reverence. The spirit of the Constitution requires us to value democratic equality over feudal submission.

### Implications for institutional integrity

By reintroducing ritualised submission into academic life, we are resurrecting an intellectual straitjacket. When a student is compelled to bow before a political figure on a dais, the message is that authority is to be obeyed, not interrogated. When a scientific convocation opens with a religious prayer, it is implied that the supernatural has a seat at the table of empirical inquiry.

Defenders will call these practices mere “cultural flourishes” – innocent tributes to India’s ancient past, meant to ground students and teach respect. But that argument falters the moment we examine it. The old *guru-shishya* paradigm, for all its reverence, demanded unquestioning obedience – the student absorbing the master’s word without debate. Modern pedagogy has moved on. It is built on Socratic dialectic – on the clash of ideas; on rigorous, respectful dissent.

The performative traditionalism often serves a political function. By wrapping themselves in the cloak of ancient culture, institutions deflect scrutiny and discourage dissent. Critics can be branded as “westernised”, “anti-national” or a recently added epithet, “*Dimagi* Naxal (intellectual extremist)” for objecting to what is, in essence, a breach of academic ethics. This rhetorical strategy is intellectually dishonest; it conflates so-called cultural pride with uncritical obedience, and tradition with truth. The result is a climate of fear – where academics and students self-censor, wary of being branded traitors for defending institutional integrity. Most Indian researchers today are too afraid to question government overreach, including their academics, for fear of retaliation.

The “Free to Think 2026” report published by Scholars at Risk (SAR) – an international network that monitors education communities worldwide – presents a comprehensive assessment of the challenges confronting India’s academic landscape. Based on data from July 1, 2025, to June 30, 2026, the report assesses academic freedom in India as “severely restricted.” The report says that India’s Academic Freedom Index score fell from 0.38 in 2022 to 0.14 in 2025, leaving it in the “severely restricted” category.

This is attributed to deterioration to systematic government interference in university

# The United Nations’ long road to restoring trust

As world leaders gathered in New York for the high-level week of the 81st United Nations General Assembly, they debated an increasingly urgent question: trust. This year’s theme, chosen by wide-ranging consultations, was: “Restoring Trust, Managing Transformation: a UN that delivers for all” – with “restoration” suggesting a collapse of trust. The world has historically been a low-trust society. Mistrust between nations has fuelled conflict throughout history. The UN was hence established after the Second World War to make the actions of nation-states more predictable, by creating a space for dialogue and an elaborate scaffolding of international law. The game of thrones would still be played, but with some rules. The UN has been one of humanity’s greatest achievements precisely because of its ability to build and channel trust between nations.

### Surveys about the UN

But over the past three decades, that ability has frayed. Where once UN staff designed and seeded “trust-building” approaches between conflicting parties as part of peacebuilding, today the organisation is in a place where it needs to restore trust in its own approaches. Two surveys conducted last year by Edelman Trust and Pew found that both trust in and favourability towards the UN had declined in the countries surveyed.

A new poll by the non-profit UN Foundation found that 52% of respondents feel the UN is struggling to deliver results and want deep structural reform. Well over half believe that it has struggled to enforce international law and protect human rights, and that it is dominated by a few powerful countries. Another poll by the Rockefeller Foundation and Focaldata suggests that only 58% think that the UN can lead efforts to solve global problems, potentially a historic low for the organisation. There are at least four reasons for this situation. First, the persistent



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The UN, one of humanity’s greatest achievements, needs to confront its deepening crisis of trust

deadlock in the UN Security Council (UNSC) has eroded the General Assembly’s trust in the UNSC, so much that a resolution was passed (A/76/262) requiring the UNSC’s permanent members to explain each new use of veto to the Assembly.

Second, questions persist about the integrity and oversight of the UN’s internal processes ranging from recruitment, procurement to allocation of resources. When high-profile controversies such as a procurement scandal in Afghanistan (2013) or sexual exploitation and abuse cases involving peacekeepers (2017) or contracts for non-existent housing projects in Ghana and India (2021) broke out in the UN, the blame was placed on individuals but systemic accountability was seldom addressed. Consequences for individual malfeasance have been limited.

### Financial muscle is a factor

Third, a few countries have come to prevail over the UN system on the strength of their financial contributions. They wield influence through advocacy for their nationals to be recruited into the system, extra-budgetary grants for cherry-picked UN programmes or a combination of the two. For instance, a 2024 report of the UN’s highest financial oversight body (ACABQ) pointed out that in one UN agency, eight out of nine technical experts recruited were sponsored by a single government. In such a case, can the policies recommended to a beneficiary country by the entity be deemed completely neutral? The UN development system’s transparency about its own programme spending too is increasingly limited to these donor governments and not to the public of their beneficiary countries. When it comes to preventing conflict, a fear of upsetting these powerful countries – which in turn could affect contributions as well as individual careers – has made the UN bureaucracy increasingly risk-averse and hesitant.

governance, suppression of dissent among faculty and students, and a pervasive climate of fear and self-censorship across Indian campuses.

The report says that the central government, led by the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party, has expanded its authority over higher education through the University Grants Commission (UGC). Measures include relaxing academic qualification criteria for Vice-Chancellors and accelerating the casualisation of the academic workforce by removing the 10% cap on non-permanent or contract-based faculty appointments. These policy shifts eliminated the previous limit on contractual faculty positions under the 2018 regulations. The report highlights that government interference in university operations – such as exerting influence over administration, curricula, and management – undermines institutional autonomy and standards of teaching; it also cites police violence against student protests as instances of direct repression of critical voices on campuses and outside.

### A call for vigilance and the Tagorean ideal

The presence of spiritual rituals and hierarchical protocols in research institutions is no trivial matter. It is a canary in the coal mine of academic freedom. If a scientist can be compelled to bow to a politician, or to sit through religious chants before a lecture, we must ask: what other compromises await? Will research agendas be steered by political piety rather than public need? Will funding be allocated based on ideological alignment rather than scientific merit, thereby rewarding sycophants?

If we are to preserve the integrity of scientific inquiry, we must insist that our universities remain sanctuaries of scepticism, not stages for spiritual theatre or political sycophancy. The future of knowledge, and indeed the future of a free and democratic society, depends on it.

If we truly wish to honour India’s legacy of cultural renaissance and critical thought, we need only turn to Rabindranath Tagore. His poem “Where the Mind is Without Fear” – written under British rule – is not a relic of nostalgic pride, but an invocation for a future world: one where people think with courage, seek truth fearlessly, and live without narrow walls of division. That is one traditional link worth defending – and perhaps even chanting at a convocation. It is a hymn to intellectual courage and the relentless pursuit of truth, not the hollow verse used to silence and intimidate. Let us reclaim the free spirit of inquiry, ensure our academic landscapes remain true to their secular purpose, and help resurrect an education sector currently in a shambles – largely due to doctrinaire rigidity, corruption and misgovernance.

Fourth, though the bulk of the UN’s programme delivery is in the Global South and trust in the UN is higher in the Global South (UN Foundation poll), only a fraction of the decision-making power rests with the Global South. Developing nations, which account for 84% of the world’s population, hold only 44% of UN civil service leadership positions. Only a third of the UN leadership in Africa is African. Only two-fifths of the cities in which various UN entities have headquarters are cities in the Global South. When, as part of a cost-cutting measure, thousands of posts were moved out of New York and Geneva in 2025, cities in the Global South (except those mentioned) got a miss despite their cost advantages.

### Reverse the shrinking space

The UN commendably delivered global humanitarian assistance and protection in 2025-26 to 98 million people, or roughly 1.1% of the world population. But aid effectiveness and the proportion of funds transferred to local actors remains an issue.

In wars such as Ukraine, Gaza and Iran, the UN made tactical interventions such as keeping grain exports flowing through the Black Sea, or preventing an oil spill in the Red Sea, but could not build on the goodwill thus earned to create mechanisms for the belligerents to sit and talk. Taking the initiative to facilitate peacemaking has become untenably centralised at the highest rungs of the organisation’s bureaucratic ladder.

It is time that the UN moved to enhance its transparency and remake its ties with the people of the world, and not just the governments. The United Nations is more than an inter-governmental organisation. It reflects the best of humanity’s hopes for itself. The “transformation” that the 81st General Assembly aims for, would indeed have to start, by restoring trust.

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### A failure to protect women

Recent reports in *The Hindu* of minor girls being molested and assaulted (September 22, 24, 25 and 28), along with other reported incidents, raise deeply troubling concerns about the continuing insecurity faced by women and girls in modern India. It is noteworthy that the top court has taken *suo motu* cognisance of grave cases of assault in the National

Capital Region (Page 1, September 29). Women’s safety must never be compromised. It is a matter of national dignity and a basic test of democracy. This is not merely about criticising one government or turning individual incidents into political arguments. It reflects a wider failure of society, which takes pride in its culture and traditions but still struggles to ensure

women’s safety. There ought to be a dedicated women’s safety police force across India, with strong representation of women officers, whose primary responsibility would be to protect women.

**Lavindar Singh,**  
Purkal, Dehradun, Uttarakhand

Women and children should be able to move freely without fear in public places. Poor lighting,

inadequate CCTV coverage and insufficient patrolling can increase safety risks. I appreciate the Supreme Court’s intervention.

**Albin Thekkethala,**  
Kallur, Thrissur, Kerala

Women should not have to calculate the safety of every road, park or journey before stepping outside. Authorities must move beyond statements of concern and ensure visible,

preventive action. Better lighting, regular patrolling, functional CCTV systems and prompt responses to complaints must become basic safeguards, rather than measures introduced only after a tragedy.

**Shruti Dutta,**  
Bengaluru

**Food loss and waste**  
In India, food grains worth several crores are lost annually due to poor

storage and transport. Ironically, the food we waste is enough to feed everyone. We must adopt a national mission to conserve food and food grains. With climate change a reality, we must also adopt sustainable practices in managing water and soil.

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Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.